

STRAY PERIL A wary pedestrian in New Delhi's Moti Nagar locality faces a pack of dogs

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Dogs for 100 people in India, a bit higher than the World Organization for Animal Health-recommended 3 dogs for 100 humans

For Noida-based homemaker Uma Sharma, 49, feeding the six stray dogs outside her home was a way to cope with the death of her husband four years ago. Without their love and loyalty, she would have gone into depression. Regretfully, members of her housing society did not share her love of dogs. A year ago, when Sharma was away on vacation, they picked up four of the six dogs and relocated them without her knowledge. "It broke my heart," she says. "I had to go in for therapy to get over the trauma. The dogs had never bitten or attacked anyone. They had been vaccinated. But due to the prejudices of some people, they paid a hefty price." Despite finding out where the dogs had been shifted, she wasn't able to locate them. Being territorial, introducing dogs to a new area often results in their death as new packs have trouble accepting an outsider.

Feeding stray dogs has been an age-old bone of contention between animal lovers and their opposers. Recently, it has been exacerbated by the rise in street dog attacks across India, triggering a public panic of sorts. In October, a three-year-old girl was killed in the Patnagarh block of Odisha's Balangir district. In September, the video of a 12-year-old boy being attacked by a stray dog in front of his house in Kerala's Kozhikode district went viral on social media. In April, a pack of stray dogs attacked two children—aged 7 and 5—in Lucknow's Musahabganj area, killing one and badly injuring the other.

While the debate over attacks by stray dogs and what to do about it rages, there is equal venting and angst on the treatment being meted out to the animals, particularly in metros. Sharma, for instance, has filed a police case against the society members for cruelty. "They are forbidden by law to touch the other two dogs," she says, adding that not just her but many children and the society guards for whom the dogs provided much-needed company felt the loss as acutely. "As long as they are not harming someone, why should we focus on getting rid of them?"

It is a question many are asking in light of the recent Bombay High Court judgment that imposes a penalty on those feeding stray dogs outside houses in Nagpur. Nearly 1,500 feeders held a silent protest against the decision at Mumbai's Shivaji Park on October 30. Their major objection is that the onus is being put on feeders instead of the local civic bodies to improve sterilisation programmes for better population control. Dog feeders, say animal experts, should not be the ones to shoulder the blame. "Feeders are doing a great service as the street dogs become more accessible to animal welfare organisations and municipal authorities to catch for sterilisation and also for re-vaccinations against rabies. Blaming feeders doesn't make sense. You say 'stop feeding dogs' and they will just disappear into thin air? It may work the other way. A dog that is well-fed is likely to be more at ease than a hungry dog. There needs to be a balance between human